

Contact Sheet		MP3 Players	
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Creative	Creative Asia Labs	9840160005	india_getcreative@ctl.creative.com
Genius	Transtek Infoways Pvt. Ltd	95-250-3250072/9821170002	amit@ttek.in
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MSI	Micro Star International Ltd.	011-51758808	info@msi-india.com
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Orite	Mediatech India	022-26361112	info@mediatechindia.com
SAFA	Arihant Computers	022 23822424	arihant_computers@vsnl.com
Samsung	Samsung Electronics India	011-4151-1234	ankhee.m@samsung.com
Sony	Sony India Pvt. Ltd.	011- 55006600	sonyindia.care@ap.sony.com
Transcend	Mediaman Infotech Pvt Ltd.	22-23828100/8200/3100/3200	sales@mediamangroup.com
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YES	Thakral Computers Pvt Ltd	9833596973	sales@raffles.co.in

HDD-based video player—the Creative Zen Vision. The Creative Zen Micro and Zen MicroPhoto’s explorer software is also easy to use, and so is Connect for the Sony NW-A1000.

A Look At Performance

Performance is just as important as features. As we have mentioned in *How We Tested*, we put these six gadgets through the same tests.

Audio Quality

The sound quality of the Sony NW-A1000 is great, with 3D effects, but it was not as detailed as the iPod’s. The iPod seemed to have the right mixture of bass and treble levels with the equaliser disabled. Tracks such as *Smack my b**ch up* by Prodigy sounded wonderful on the iPod. So was *Punjab* by Karunesh—each note was clear and distinct.

The Creative Zen Micro series, too, delivered quality audio. Sony’s NW-A1000 rendered tracks by Joe Satriani and Steve Vai well. The other Sony—the NW-HD5—simply did not belong in the league of Sony! Whether the problem was with the unit or the earphones, the sound just wasn’t up to the mark.

Without a doubt, the Apple iPod leads in audio quality, followed by the Creative Zen Micro series and the Sony NW-A1000.

Data Transfer

The result of this test mainly depends on the syncing software bundled with the product. iTunes did well to help the Apple iPod score the fastest transfer,



Apple iPod 30 GB (Video)

with the Sony NW-A1000 on its tail. The Creative players fell on the slower side.

Battery Life

The Sony NW-HD5 clocked over 24 hours of battery life! The NW-A1000 could manage a little less than half the time set by its cousin. However, Sony claims higher battery life for both their products, and we think their figures are a bit optimistic.

The Creative Zen Neeon is in second place, recording 18 hours in the battery drain test. For a change, the iPod fell into the last spot with the lowest battery life of seven hours, about an hour and a half less than the Creative Zen MicroPhoto.

The Winner

This test did not see stiff competition, and we can conceivably attribute this to the absence of players from iRiver and Samsung, which were adjudged the winners last time round.

The quality of the Apple iPod is never in doubt, but it lacks features



Creative Zen MicroPhoto

such as an FM tuner. Nevertheless, the inclusion of video playback and the drop in the price tag has ensured that the Apple iPod 30 GB Video wins this battle hands down. It is a pleasure to award the Digit Best Buy Gold to a player with such amazing sound quality. The Creative Zen MicroPhoto comes second, and takes the Digit Best Buy Silver.

In Conclusion

We have seen a lot of improvement in MP3 players in a very short period. When we last tested MP3 players, the Samsung units (YP-T8 and YH-J70) bordered on being “Portable Digital Media Players” rather than being just digital audio players. If the trend continues, we will see more features added. In fact, this time, we saw an upgrade of the Samsung YP-T8 in the form of the YP-D1, with an added 2-megapixel camera and improved sound quality.

Manufacturers are aiming at the “Portable Digital Media Center” segment. We have witnessed the launch of players such as the Creative Zen Vision to fill this category. Others such as the Archos AV400 and the iRiver PMP have already made a name in this category. We’re even seeing Flash-based players aiming for the same bouquet of features as their HDD-based cousins. ■

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